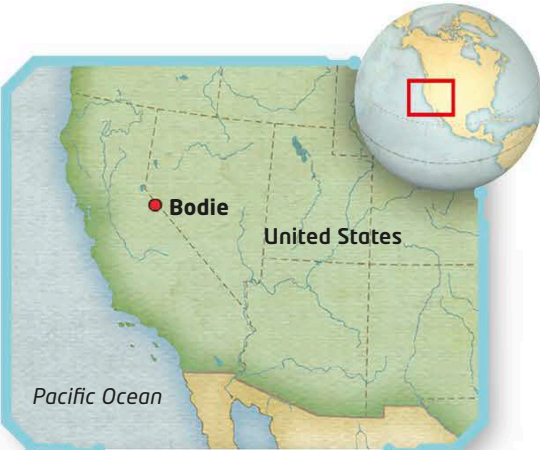


BOOM TOWN

In 1859, a man called W. S. Bodey found gold in a remote part of California. Before he could exploit his discovery, Bodey froze to death in a blizzard, but the news of the gold spread. People flocked to the area seeking jobs, and the town of Bodie was born. By 1880, its population had reached 7,000. But as the gold ran out most of the inhabitants left, and today Bodie is a ghost town.



The American West

Bodie lies 8,375 ft (2,553 m) up in the Sierra Nevada mountains, in Mono County, California. The area is dusty and dry, hot in summer and freezing in winter.

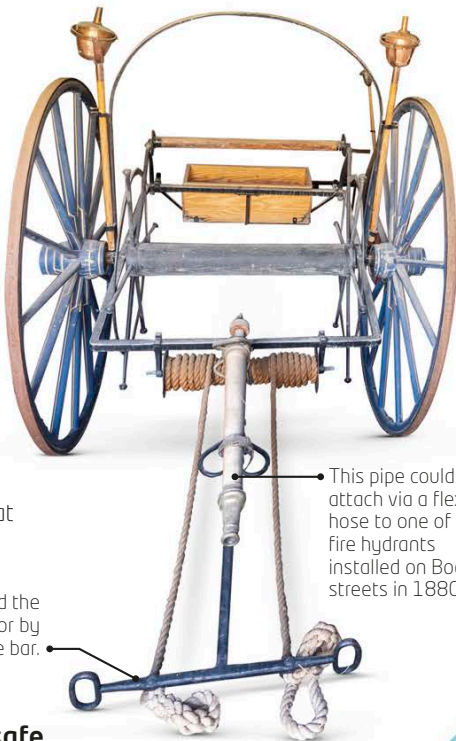


The Standard Mill

The biggest building in Bodie today is known as the Standard Mill. It took material dug up by miners and separated the gold and silver in it from less valuable minerals. This industrial process caused much environmental damage.

Fighting fires

As Bodie was a town built mostly of wood, fires were a constant concern. At one time it had four separate fire companies, with carriages loaded with water pumps that were operated by hand.



This pipe could attach via a flexible hose to one of the fire hydrants installed on Bodie's streets in 1880.

This T-shaped shaft allowed the wagon to be pulled by horses or by men holding onto the bar.

Keeping the streets safe

Law enforcement in Bodie was the responsibility of John F. Kirgan, the town's jailer and constable. Fights, shootings, and stabbings sometimes took place in the town, but Kirgan and his team worked hard to keep the peace.

Bodie's jail was small and only had two cells.



A ghost town

Bodie's last residents left in the 1960s, leaving their possessions behind. Today, the buildings are preserved in a form of "arrested decay." This means that no one is allowed to move anything in any of the houses.

